



Figure 3: My work laptop with the Folder View, Notes, Picture Frame and RSSNow widgets

the traditional versions, with icons and files all over the place. You can set it by accessing the *Appearance Settings* option by right clicking on your desktop and then changing your desktop activity type from 'Desktop' to 'Folder View'. But I don't think it's a good idea, especially if you are someone like me who keeps downloading random stuff from the Web, and storing it on the ~/Desktop folder, turning the desktop into a huge pool of icons. That's why I would rather use Folder View as a widget than use it as *my desktop*. The reason being that I can set its size to what I want and use the rest of the desktop to put other useful widgets, without worrying about my ~/Desktop folder becoming a junkyard of trash downloads from all over the Web.

This brings me to the other useful widgets I use. The Calvin and Hobbs is courtesy the Comic Strip widget, and it works provided you're connected to the Internet. When you launch it, you first need to set it up. You can pull comic streams from a wide range of streams hosted at KDE-Files.org—so whether you're into Garfield, Dilbert, or anybody else, you are free to choose from a list that's more than a handful. This is a healthy addition considering v4.1.x only provided me with an option of a few.

The pictures are courtesy the Picture Frame widget. Here, you can simply drag and drop pictures and the widget adjusts its size according to the dimensions (landscape or portrait) of the source image. Don't worry, the widget doesn't depend on the resolution of the source image—it's intelligent enough to give you a good-sized picture frame, and you are free to increase or decrease it as per your taste. This is a very useful addition for me, as earlier I used to remix an image with lots of elements (and faces) to create wallpaper. Now, I can simply select an image of some scenery for a wall paper, while pictures of people go into frames. :-)

For my work desktop, I like to track a few news sites and the RSSNow widget lets me do exactly that. Each feed automatically scrolls horizontally to show me the current news—and of course, it gives me the option to manually skim through them. When I chance upon something interesting, I click, and the default browser loads the Web page with the complete story.

Another handy widget is *pastebin*. If you hang out in IRC channels, I don't need to explain what *pastebins* are. You probably point your browser to a *pastebin* website, upload the information and then obtain the URL to share with others. Instead, the widget connects



Figure 4: Lancelot launcher

to *pastebin.ca* for you, so all you need to do is drag and drop text or images here, and it gives you the URL that you can post in the IRC channel you're logged in to. Makes life a lot easier, right?

Other widgets that you may find handy are the age-old binary clock, Blue Marble (a 3D model of the earth that's rendered thanks to the Marble application—a Google Earth-like tool), Calculator, Dictionary, Eyes, Fifteen Puzzle, LCD Weather Station (to keep an eye on the current weather of your city), Luna (to check the current phase of the moon), Twitter Microblogging client, World Clock, various system monitors (to monitor your hard disk, CPU temperature, network traffic and other hardware information), besides a lot more that don't really seem interesting enough to me. I also hope some of these widgets get the attention of the artists teams to make them look more appealing, like the system monitors that take up too much screen space and look too dull.

Before ending my rant on the widgets, allow me to draw your attention to the Lancelot Launcher menu in Figure 4. Although, technically it's more or less similar to Kickoff, I like the way things are organised here, besides the fact that it looks more appealing. After customising a few of its settings, I've finally switched to Lancelot as my default launcher menu. Although, I hardly use even *this*: which brings me to...